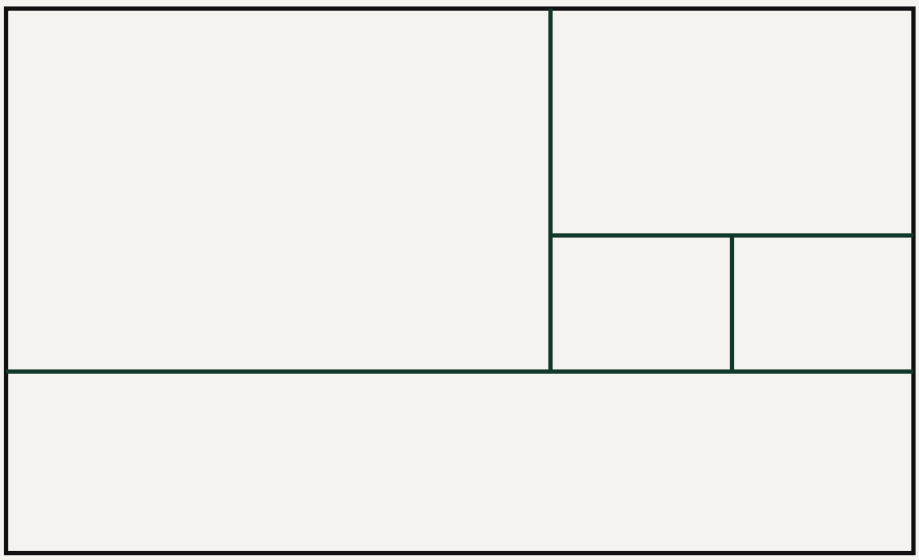
Keep what works. Make room for change.

Architecture through retention, adaptation and useful space.



RETAIN THE FRAME / REWORK THE PLAN

VOL. 01 / 2026

A quieter kind of architecture.

Rooms that work hard. Buildings that sit lightly.

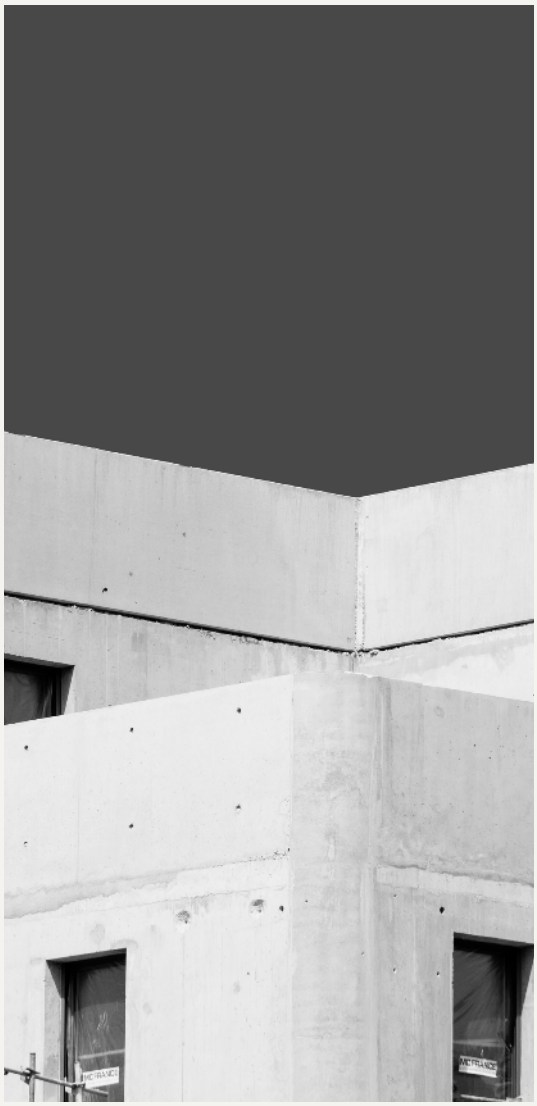
A useful plan.
A lasting material.
A measured response.

A building begins long before its first line is drawn. It begins with a walk across the site, a conversation at the kitchen table, the sound of traffic behind a garden wall. Those small observations tell us what a place needs and what it can do without.

Halvorsen & Quill is an independent architecture studio working across homes, small public buildings and the careful reuse of existing structures. Our work brings ordinary routines into focus: arriving with wet coats, finding a quiet seat, opening a room to a courtyard, making a shared entrance feel generous.

We prefer a clear plan to an elaborate gesture. A few well-chosen materials carry each project from the outside wall to the smallest junction. Daylight gives rooms their rhythm; a useful threshold makes the transition between them feel natural. Where an existing building has value, we keep it and work with its character.

Every commission receives the same attention to proportion, movement and the life of materials. The result is architecture with enough structure to support daily use and enough room to change as that use evolves.



Made for everyday life.

A small practice with a shared way of working.

The studio was formed around a simple observation: people rarely describe their favourite rooms by naming a style. They talk about the light at a certain hour, a view from a chair, a place where everyone naturally gathers.

Our team of eight works together from the first survey to the final site inspection. Design and delivery remain part of the same conversation. The person discussing a window position with a client also understands the detail that makes it weather-tight.

We begin each commission with a written brief, a measured account of the site and a review of what can be retained. We then test alternatives with plans, sections and physical material samples. Each stage ends with a clear record of decisions, costs and the work still to resolve.

This approach suits clients who value considered design and direct communication. It also keeps attention on the building itself: how it is put together, how it will be maintained and how it can remain useful over time.

08

people

24

selected studies

03

design principles

Read the site.

Begin with what is already there.

Ground, orientation and neighbouring buildings shape the first decisions. We record the sun's path, the points of arrival and the views worth holding. Existing trees and structures are part of the brief rather than obstacles drawn over later.

The best site response often comes from a small adjustment: turning an entrance away from the wind, lowering a roof beside a neighbour, moving a living room towards the late afternoon light. We test these moves early, while the plan is still open to change.

The three principles shown here guide that work. They are questions to return to at every stage, from a first sketch to a junction on site.

01



Read the site

Trace light, access and the existing fabric before placing a new volume.

02



Make a useful plan

Give daily routines clear paths and rooms with more than one possible use.

03



Build for time

Choose repairable materials and details that can be understood, maintained and adapted.

Let the light do the work.

A good section is as important as a good plan.

Daylight changes the character of a room without changing its footprint. A high opening can bring light deep into a plan while keeping a street-facing wall private. A shaded courtyard can soften strong sun and create a place to sit outside for more of the day.

We study the section alongside the plan. Ceiling height, window depth and the position of a rooflight influence how a space feels and how it performs. We use those relationships before adding another finish or fitting.

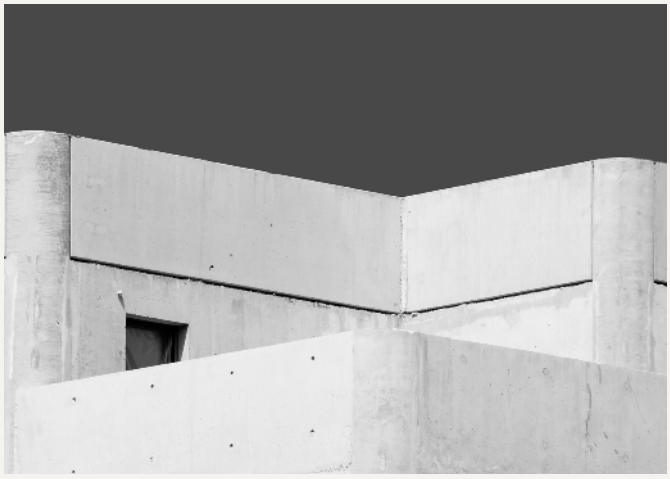
Material decisions follow the same discipline. A limited palette allows transitions to feel calm and makes the construction easier to read. Surfaces are selected for their likely use, their ability to be repaired and the way they will age. The ambition is a building that becomes more familiar with time.

Light is a material.

Give it space.



Light / Wesley Shen



Material / Pierre Châtel-Innocenti

01
The Courtyard House

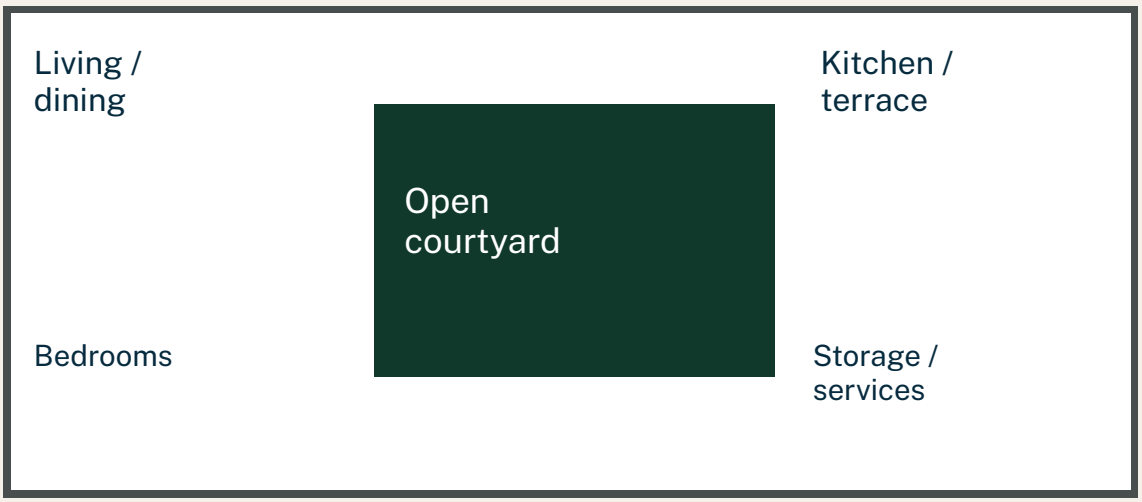


A compact home gathered around an open centre.

A narrow site called for privacy without closing the house to daylight. The response is a simple perimeter with a courtyard at its heart. Living spaces face the garden; service rooms form a quieter edge towards the lane.

Architectural reference
Mike Bird / Pexels

COURTYARD / SPATIAL STUDY



Schematic relationships; not a measured plan.

A room without a roof.

The courtyard sets the rhythm of the plan.

Privacy at the edge.

Openness at the centre.

The garden is visible from each shared room, but it is never seen in exactly the same way. A deep window frames its upper branches. A low bench gives the living room an informal edge. The kitchen opens to a sheltered place for morning coffee.

The plan keeps circulation compact. A route around the courtyard connects the rooms without a long corridor, and storage is built into the thickness of the inner edge. Bedrooms sit beyond a separate threshold so the shared space can remain active in the evening.

Openings are sized for their position. The street elevation is quiet; the garden elevation is generous. That difference allows the house to feel protected and open at the same time.

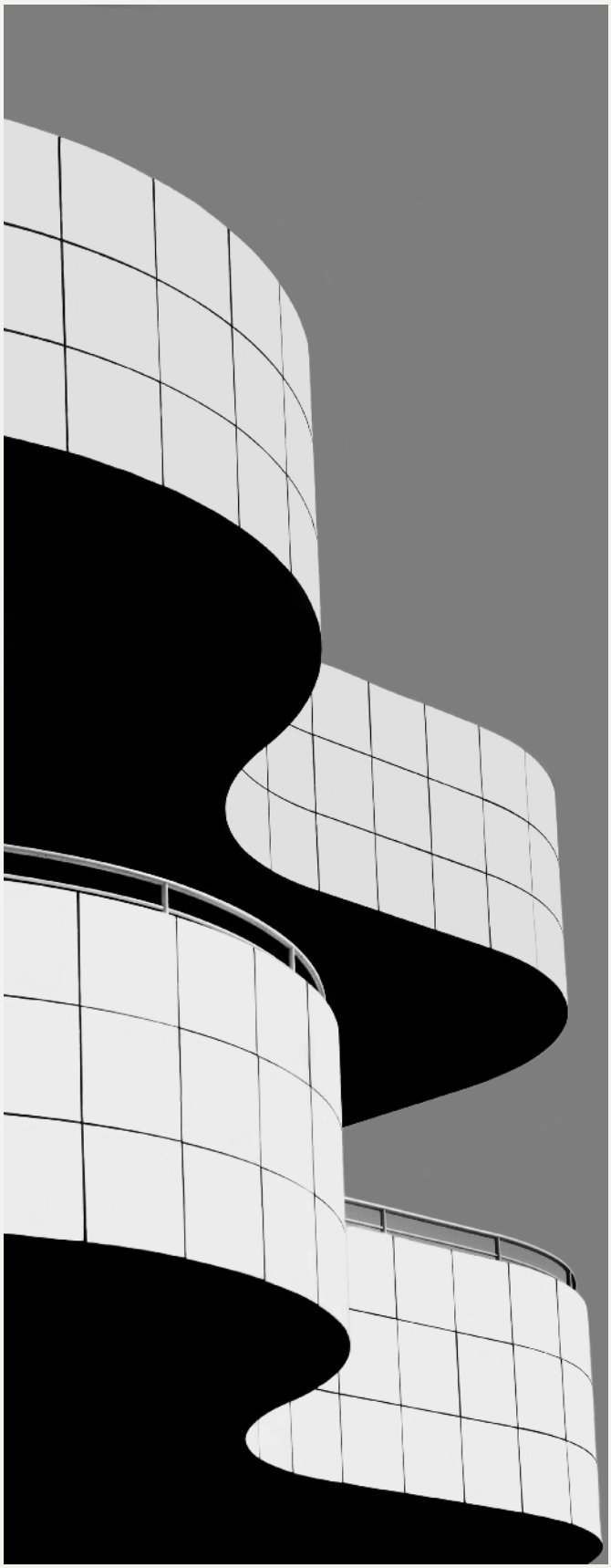
02
The Northbank Rooms

An existing shell, made useful again.

This study begins with a former storage building whose heavy structure remains sound. Rather than divide it into identical rooms, the proposal introduces a sequence of shared spaces with different degrees of openness.

A central gathering room can host talks, workshops and an ordinary weekday lunch. Smaller rooms sit along its edges for meetings and concentrated work. The entrance makes the building easy to understand on a first visit, with a direct view to the shared heart.

Keeping the main structure reduces the amount of new construction and preserves the scale of the original building. New insertions are deliberately legible: timber screens, simple thresholds and a clear service spine.



Architectural reference / Cat Han

Adaptive reuse	Northbank	640 m²	2025

Keep the frame. Change the use.

A measured approach to an existing building.

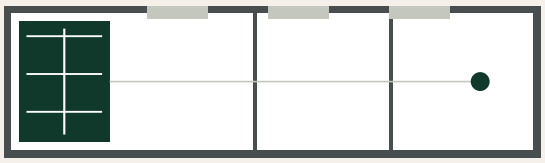
Retain the shell



Insert a service spine



Adapt the rooms



Conceptual study / not to scale

The design separates the work into three kinds of intervention. Repairs protect the existing shell. A service spine brings new uses into the building without distributing plant through every room. Lightweight partitions provide enclosure while leaving the primary structure visible.

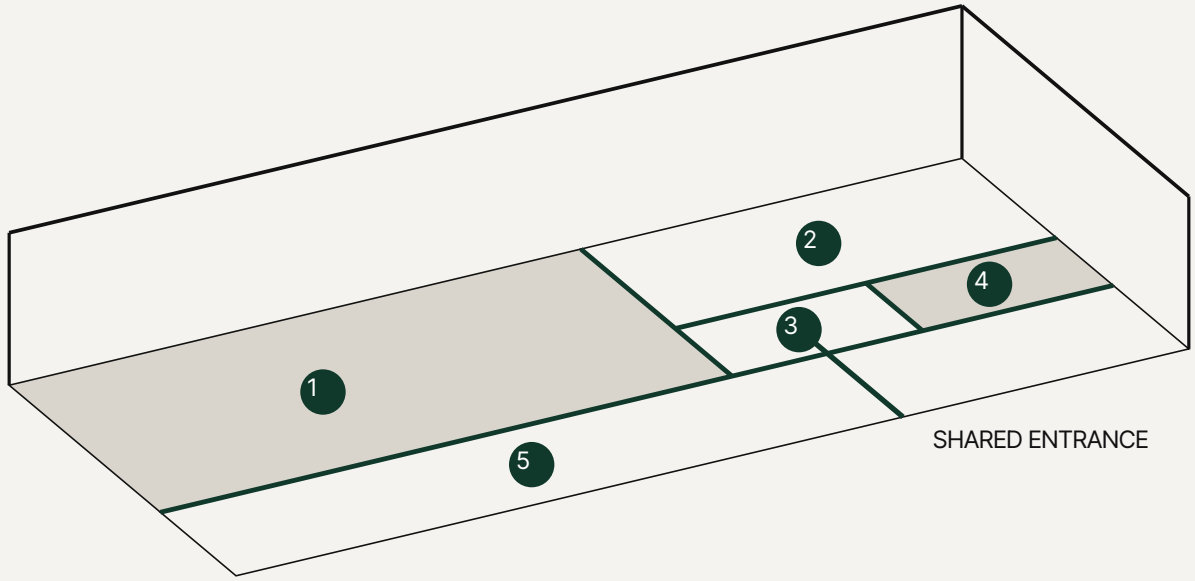
The shared room receives the strongest daylight and the clearest route from the entrance. Other spaces borrow light through high internal openings. The arrangement can change as the programme grows, with a pair of small rooms becoming one larger workshop.

The project shows how a useful plan can emerge from an existing frame. Its character comes from the relationship between retained structure and new use, with neither made to imitate the other.

RETAIN / INSERT / ADAPT

A public front.
A quiet interior.

An existing 20 x 12 m shell, reorganised for shared use.



ORIGINAL AXONOMETRIC / ROOF OMITTED / KEY MATCHES PLAN

RETAINED SHELL

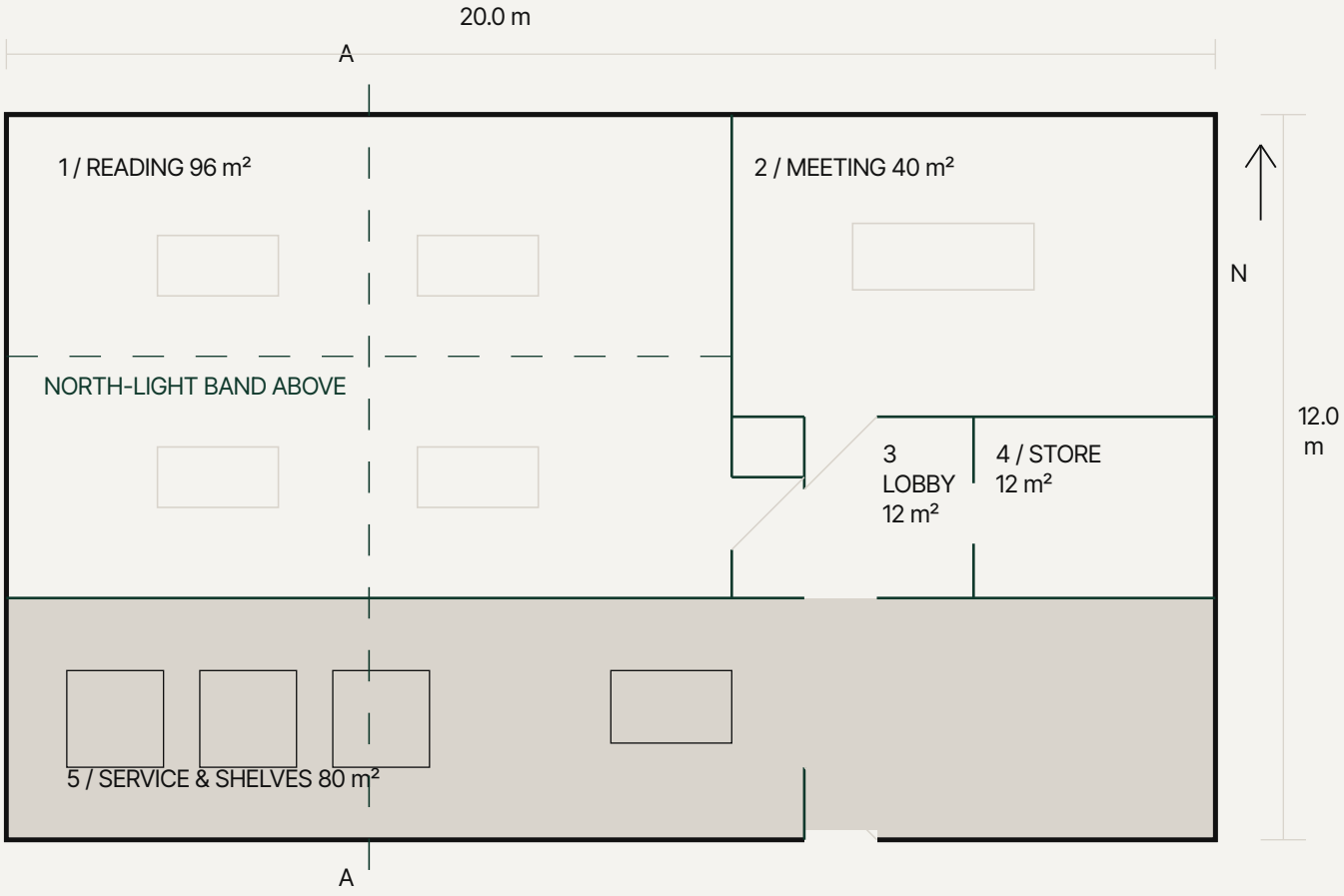
The brief keeps the sound perimeter and gives a public reading room a clear arrival. An evening meeting room sits close to the entrance, beyond its own threshold.

NEW PARTITIONS

New partitions organise the 240 m² gross envelope. A compact service edge keeps the reading space open. The plan and north-light section test the same proposed geometry.

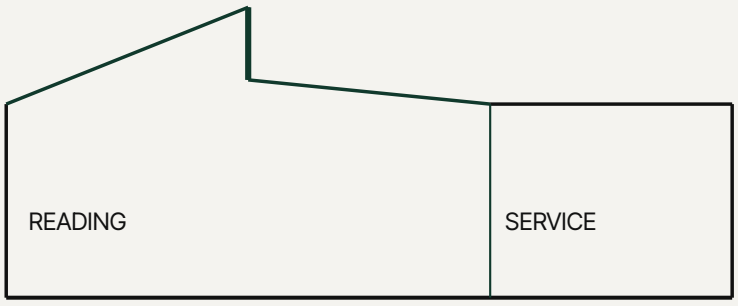
One shell.
Five useful zones.

PLAN 1:125 / A-A N-S / GROSS ENVELOPE 240 m²



AREA KEY / 96+40+12+12+80=240 m² / WALLS INCLUDED

SECTION A-A / NORTH LIGHT / SCALE 1:125



4.8 m high point
3.2 m service edge
North-facing glass

Schematic proposal; not a survey or construction document.

Twenty-four ways of working.

Homes, shared spaces and buildings given a second life.

24
selected studies

07
years recorded

03
project types

01
shared approach

The selected index records the studio’s range in a compact format. Each study begins with its own site and programme. The common thread is a plan that makes daily use clear and a material approach suited to its setting.

Residential work includes courtyard houses, small additions and the reorganisation of existing homes. Shared buildings include reading rooms, workshops and places to gather. Reuse studies ask which parts of a building should remain and where a limited intervention can unlock a new use.

Selected studies 2020–2026

No.	Study	Type	Place	Year
01	Courtyard House	Residential	Northbank	2026
02	Northbank Rooms	Reuse	Northbank	2025
03	Lantern Library	Public	Eastmere	2026
04	Orchard House	Residential	Vale End	2026
05	Mill Yard Studio	Reuse	Millford	2025
06	The Long Room	Public	Westmere	2025
07	Garden Threshold	Residential	Elm Reach	2024
08	Corner Workshop	Reuse	Northbank	2024
09	Hill House	Residential	Ridgewell	2024
10	Market Hall Annex	Public	Millford	2024
11	Brick Lane Rooms	Reuse	Eastmere	2023
12	River Terrace	Residential	Westmere	2023
13	The Small School	Public	Vale End	2023
14	Courtyard Annex	Residential	Elm Reach	2023
15	Old Stores	Reuse	Ridgewell	2022
16	Field Pavilion	Public	Vale End	2022
17	Terrace Reworked	Residential	Northbank	2022
18	Neighbourhood Desk	Public	Eastmere	2022
19	Stone Yard	Reuse	Millford	2021
20	Rooflight House	Residential	Westmere	2021
21	Sheltered Court	Residential	Elm Reach	2021
22	The Reading Shed	Public	Ridgewell	2021
23	Two Rooms Added	Residential	Vale End	2020
24	Workshop Garden	Reuse	Northbank	2020

Good work is shared work.

Recognition, learning and the value of collaboration.

Our work depends on a close exchange with clients, engineers, makers and contractors. A clear design becomes a useful building through their combined knowledge. We value the practical conversation that improves a detail before it is built.

The studio's internal review programme records what each completed stage has taught us. We compare early intentions with later decisions, discuss details that worked well and note where a different approach would serve the next project better.

The recognition register below forms part of this publication's original studio narrative. It is kept separate from professional qualifications and statutory approvals.



2026	Courtyard Design Review Courtyard House / selected study
2025	Reuse Practice Forum Northbank Rooms / presentation
2024	Small Spaces Review Garden Threshold / selected study

Tell us about your place.

A first conversation starts with the site and what you need.

Bring the address, a few photographs and an outline of how you would like the building to work. If you have drawings, a planning history or an initial budget, those are useful too. The brief can remain open; part of our work is helping to make it clear.

We begin with a short conversation to understand the scope, timing and fit. A site visit follows where the commission requires one. We then set out the proposed stages, the information needed and a fee for the agreed work.

For new buildings, additions and reuse studies, the first useful question is the same: what should this place make possible?

Studio enquiries

studio@halvorsen-quill.example

By appointment

Northbank / Eastmere

01 / Conversation

02 / Site and brief

03 / Options

04 / Developed design

05 / Delivery



H & Q

A place for living.
A plan for time.

HALVORSEN & QUILL / ARCHITECTURE